

And that's pretty much it to get up and running with GanttProject, but here's something about the interesting features it brings with it.

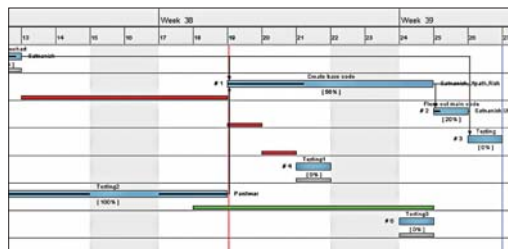
A Features Run-Down

Space does not permit a step-by-step discussion of how to get things done, but then it's pretty easy, like we said.

"Milestone" can be set as an attribute for a task that needs to be watched. We won't go into the details, but suffice it to say that if a "milestone" task has been completed, the graph changes in an interesting way. Try it.

Colour coding seems silly in general: no one needs pretty, colourful labels, but they're almost of the essence in the at-a-glance school of thought. So, with the default colours, things look pretty staid when everything's going fine; then, when something finishes early, you have a cheerful yellow bar indicating free time; and what's most useful is the red marks, which indicate events that deserve your immediate attention. This works with resources, too: when someone is overloaded, you get a red mark for the day, and also a figure about whether he has 150, 200, etc. per cent more work than assumed. This is indicated so that you buy him a pizza.

An interesting feature added to the 2.0 version of GanttProject—and a very useful one at that—is the ability to compare "states." At any point, you can save the current state of affairs using the *Save state* button, and you can always use *Compare to previous* to look



We've compared a current state with an earlier one. Coloured bars appear underneath tasks in date ranges. A red bar indicates a problem that's now holding up the task; green means "on schedule." All at a glance!

back in time. Imagine you've pushed ahead some deadlines; if you'd saved the state before you did that, you could compare the current project state with the earlier one—and what you'll get are red, green, and yellow bars. A green bar is a pat on the back: this task is still on schedule. A red bar under a task means it's now going to take longer to complete, and a yellow bar means it'll now complete sooner than it would have. Which days the bars come under is dictated by the task's dependencies.

The Critical Path Method (CPM)

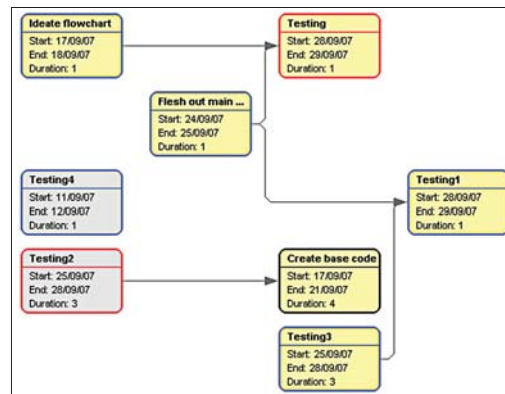
GanttProject has the Critical Path function, using which you can see when your project can be completed at the earliest, and what tasks along the path that is displayed need, well, critical attention. From *The Free Encyclopedia That Anyone Can Edit*, "CPM is an algorithm for scheduling a set of project activities. In project management,

a critical path is the sequence of project network activities with the longest overall duration, determining the shortest time possible to complete the project. Any delay of an activity on the critical path directly impacts the planned project completion date."

If you construct a simple project and press *Critical path*, nothing much will show up—the last task to be completed will get highlighted, and that's about it. You'll see the value of the method when you have a sufficiently detailed project; you'll see bottlenecks you wouldn't have intuited.

The PERT Chart

Another way of looking at things, getting away from Mr Gantt's worldview, is the PERT chart,



Each task is a node here. The yellow nodes here have dependencies. Those with a red outline have problems (bottom left, for example). Arrows indicate dependencies; details are in the node boxes

standing for Program Evaluation Review Technique. This, using GanttProject, looks as below. It has events as nodes, it shows dependencies, there are good-thing-and-bad-news colour indicators, and more. Space does not permit a discussion, but suffice it to say that some project managers prefer the PERT chart over the Gantt chart—and many use both at the same time. Good for us, because GanttProject, untrue to its name, provides both. We'd advise you to get familiar with the PERT chart the do-it-yourself way: create a simple project and look at the PERT chart for it. (The PERT tab is activated from the View menu.)

So Download It!

It's not hard to get hooked to this nifty piece of software which, at first glance, seems simplistic. Even individuals could develop a fondness for it, it's so easy to use. But it has sufficient power to aid any business project.

For all we've seen and heard, you won't be getting much of your money's worth if you spend on MS Project—assuming, of course, that you're sold on project management software.

Which is a good thing to happen to you, we should add. It's better than mind maps, it's better than Excel (however familiar you might be with it), and it's better than caffeine overdose. ☒

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